

Bringing a Coaching Mindset to Supervision and Leadership

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Abstract

Developing people is a key part of our work as academics, whether as leaders, managers or supervisors. Yet we are rarely trained how to play these roles. Responsibility can weigh heavily to give the right advice and have the answers. Is this the best approach? This course will offer a set of practical conversational techniques that focus on the power of good listening and asking good questions. Such a coaching mindset is much more effective for helping people develop as independent resourceful academics/researchers. It also means you doing less to achieve more.

CCS Concepts

• **Social and professional topics;**

Keywords

Coaching-mindset, Academic development, Management, Good questions, Supervision

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1 Benefits

Developing people is a key part of our role as academic/research leaders, managers and supervisors. In wanting to do a good job, we can take on the pressure of having to be the one with all the answers and we are often too quick to give advice. But what if our well-intentioned answers and advice can be the most unhelpful thing we can do? In doing so, we can set ourselves up to be a bottleneck in all solution-finding and decision-making. We can feel weighed down by the responsibility. We also set up our students/researchers to be dependent on us and we miss everyday opportunities to promote their autonomy and development and enable their learning.

Drawing on techniques used in coaching, this course offers practical conversational techniques for leaders, managers and supervisors to be more effective, with less work and without the burden of having to know all the answers, while at the same time empowering and growing the people we work with [1]. This is based on the

simple skill of learning how to listen better and how to ask good questions before jumping in with advice.

Specifically, attendees will learn to:

- Identify the range of different support ‘hats’ we can wear as leaders, managers and supervisors
- Understand what makes people tick and recognise how the ‘advice monster’ works against this
- Understand the developmental value of staying curious, listening deeply, and asking good questions

2 Intended Audience(s)

This course is suitable to anyone in a leadership, management or supervisory position. While examples will largely be drawn from an academic context, the skills are generic and directly applicable to anyone in research, academia or industry.

3 Prerequisites

No prerequisites other than being in a position of leading, managing or supervising others.

4 Content

The content of the course will be delivered in one 75-minute session, exploring:

- How a coaching mindset fits as part of an overall toolkit of interactional roles we can play.
- Why the ‘advice’ monster can be counter-productive to helping people develop and also creates an extra burden of responsibility.
- An evidence-based approach for a coaching mindset based on good listening skills and good questioning skills, with example questions.

5 Practical work

This will be a highly interactive course where all participants are invited to contribute shared experiences, challenges and suggestions.

6 Instructor background

Geraldine Fitzpatrick is a recently retired full professor at TU Wien in Austria and an ACM Distinguished Scientist, IFIP Fellow, TC-13 Pioneer Award recipient, SIGCHI Lifetime Service Award and TU Best Teacher award, having also served as an ACM Distinguished Speaker. Apart from her Informatics degrees and PhD in the area of CSCW/HCI, she has a Masters in Applied Positive Psychology and Coaching Psychology, and 15+ years’ experience as a trained facilitator and coach (leadership, personal, professional, group). She has an extensive background in leading and developing people in diverse contexts in Australia, UK and Austria: research groups and

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institutes/labs in academic contexts, as a charge nurse of various hospital departments (before her academic career) and as a Senior Manager of User Experience in industry. She is passionate about how we can craft better academic cultures, hosts the Changing Academic Life podcast series. She also delivers academic career development consultancy, training and coaching internationally and co-facilitates Academic Leadership Development courses for Informatics Europe. Web page: <https://www.geraldinefitzpatrick.com>

7 Resources

Personal web page: <https://www.geraldinefitzpatrick.com>

TU Wien Web page: <http://igw.tuwien.ac.at/hci/people/gfitzpatrick>

Changing Academic Life podcast page: <http://www.changingacademiclife.com/> for related conversations on a coaching mindset and asking good questions.

Informatics Europe Academic Leadership Development Courses Web page: <https://www.informatics-europe.org/events/academic-leadership-development.html>

8 Accessibility

To optimize accessibility, all slides will be consistent and in keeping with colour-blind friendly best practices, with live voice-to-text transcription for those with hearing difficulties as feasible. Activities will be appropriately chunked and contain different formats to allow for different styles of interaction, and rest breaks will be embedded in the schedule.

Acknowledgments

To all the people I have worked with over the years who have been a critical part of my own learning journey towards trying to do better, be better as a leader, manager and supervisor. And for their tolerance and forgiveness when I don't get it so right!

References

- [1] Laura Cruz and LaNise Rosemond. 2017. Coaching academia: The integration of coaching, educational development, and the culture of higher education. *J. Excellences in College Teaching*, 28, 4, 83108. 604–632.